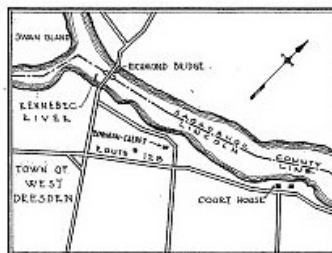


# POWNALBOROUGH COURT HOUSE

CEDAR GROVE  
LINCOLN COUNTY  
MAINE



SKETCH MAP  
SHOWING LOCATION

ERECTED 1761

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY  
U.S. DEPARTMENT OF THE INTERIOR  
NATIONAL PARK SERVICE  
BRANCH OF PLANS AND DESIGN

MEASURED: JULY 7, 1936 - JULY 30, 1936  
DRAWN: OCT. 1, 1936 - NOV. 15, 1936  
MEASUREMENTS CHECKED: JOSIAH T. TURSEY



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SURVEY NO.  
ME 42  
19 SHEETS

INDEX NO.  
ME 42  
1-

# POWNALBOROUGH COURT HOUSE

*The 1936 Historic American  
Buildings Survey*

Aric Wilmunder

A Well-Regulated Press

Novato, California

2026

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# Preface

Historic buildings connect us to the people who came before us. Their walls have witnessed public debates, quiet conversations, celebrations, hardships, and the ordinary routines of everyday life. Some of these stories survive in letters, diaries, newspapers, and photographs. Others remain written into the buildings themselves, waiting to be discovered in worn stair treads, hand-forged hinges, weathered timbers, and carefully crafted woodwork.

The Pownalborough Court House, erected in 1761, is one of Maine's oldest surviving public buildings. It served as the seat of government for Lincoln County before becoming the home of the Johnson and Prescott families in the nineteenth century. Today it is preserved as a museum, allowing visitors to experience more than two and a half centuries of Maine history under one roof.

By the 1930s, many of America's historic buildings had already been altered or lost. Recognizing the need to preserve an accurate record of the nation's architectural heritage, the federal government established the Historic American Buildings Survey (HABS) in 1933. Just three years later, a team of architects, draftsmen, and a photographer arrived at the Pownalborough Court House to create one of the earliest comprehensive records of the building.

Over the course of their survey, they measured rooms, fireplaces, stairways, windows, doors, and structural framing, recording details that might otherwise have been forgotten. Their work produced nineteen meticulously drafted sheets, a series of photographs, and a written historical record that together remain among the most valuable resources for understanding the courthouse not just as it appeared in 1936, but also as it had evolved over time.

At first glance, these records may seem intended only for architects or historians. In reality, they tell a much broader story. The measured drawings reveal how the courthouse was constructed and altered. The photographs show the building as the surveyors encountered it in 1936, weathered, furnished, and still in use. The written record preserves their understanding of its materials, construction, alterations, and history. Together, they offer a fascinating glimpse into the methods and standards of one of America's earliest historic preservation programs.

This guide was created to help readers explore that survey. Rather than simply reproducing the original HABS materials, it examines what they document, why they were created, and what they reveal about the building. Whether you are visiting the courthouse for the first time, researching its history, studying early American architecture, or simply curious about how historic buildings are documented, these pages are intended to make one of the nation's finest historic building surveys accessible to everyone.

# **PART I**

## **THE POWNALBOROUGH COURT HOUSE**

# **The Kennebec: A River to the Sea**

Long before there was a Pownalborough, a Fort Shirley, or a Court House, there was the Kennebec.

Flowing from the interior of what is now Maine to the Atlantic, the Kennebec was one of the great natural highways of the region. Long before European settlement, Wabanaki people traveled its waters by canoe, following routes that connected communities, fishing grounds, and hunting territories with the coast and the interior. The river and its tributaries were not boundaries separating communities, but pathways connecting them.

The Kennebec watershed was part of the homeland of the Abenaki, one of the peoples of the Wabanaki Confederacy. Wabanaki is often translated as “People of the Dawnland” or “People of the East,” a name rooted in their homeland toward the rising sun. For thousands of years, they lived along and traveled the river and its tributaries, fished its waters, hunted in the surrounding forests, and gave names to the places along its course.

Even the name Kennebec predates European settlement. Derived from an Abenaki name for the waterway, it has been variously translated as “long still water,” “long pond,” or “bay.” Whatever its precise original meaning, the name itself is a reminder that Europeans arriving on the Kennebec were entering a landscape whose rivers, settlements, and landmarks had already been named and understood for generations.

The river also provided food. Seasonal runs of salmon, shad, alewives, eels, and other migratory fish moved between the Atlantic and the upper watershed. Native communities along the Kennebec combined fishing, hunting, gathering,

and, in parts of the watershed, agriculture. The river was not simply a route through the landscape. It was central to life along it.

When Europeans began moving up the Kennebec, they followed a waterway that had been traveled for generations.

At the mouth of the river, English colonists established the short-lived Popham Colony in 1607. Although the settlement survived for little more than a year, it marked an early English attempt to establish a permanent settlement on the Maine coast. In 1628, Plymouth Colony established a trading post farther upriver at Cushnoc, near present-day Augusta. From there, English traders exchanged goods with Native people and gained access to the interior by way of the river.

The Kennebec made that movement possible. Ocean-going vessels could enter from the Atlantic, while smaller boats and canoes traveled farther upstream. People, furs, provisions, tools, correspondence, and eventually building materials moved along the water. Long before roads connected the settlements along its banks, the river connected them to one another and to the coast.

As English settlement expanded during the seventeenth and eighteenth centuries, the Kennebec became part of a contested region between New England and New France. For the Abenaki communities already living there, the arrival of European traders and settlers brought profound changes. Trade created new relationships, while disease, warfare, competing territorial claims, and expanding settlement disrupted communities and increasingly threatened Native control of their homeland.

**PART II**

**THE HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS**

**SURVEY**

# **Preserving America's Architectural Heritage**

Historic buildings are among our nation's most tangible connections to the past. They preserve the craftsmanship, materials, and architectural traditions of earlier generations while providing a physical setting for the events that shaped local communities and the nation as a whole. Every hand-hewn timber, worn floorboard, and precisely carved molding reflects the skills of the people who built them and the lives of those who later occupied them.

By the early twentieth century, however, many of America's oldest buildings were disappearing. Expanding cities, changing transportation networks, economic pressures, and modern construction practices led to the demolition or alteration of countless historic structures. While some buildings were preserved through local efforts, many others vanished without leaving behind an accurate record of their appearance or construction.

Architects, historians, and preservationists recognized that once a building was lost, so too was much of the knowledge it contained. If every room, doorway, staircase, fireplace, and structural detail could be measured and recorded, future generations would still be able to study these noteworthy buildings even if they no longer survived. Accurate measured drawings, accompanied by photographs and written histories, offered a way to preserve America's architectural heritage for future generations.

This vision led to the creation of the Historic American Buildings Survey, a national program dedicated to documenting the country's most significant historic buildings with a level of precision and care never before attempted on such a scale.

# **The Great Depression and the Birth of HABS**

The Historic American Buildings Survey (HABS) was established in 1933 during the depths of the Great Depression. At a time when unemployment affected nearly every profession, many architects found themselves without work as construction projects came to a halt across the country.

Recognizing both the need to employ skilled professionals and the importance of preserving America's historic architecture, the National Park Service partnered with the American Institute of Architects and the Library of Congress to create a nationwide documentation program. Rather than constructing new buildings, teams of architects, draftsmen, and photographers would record historic structures through painstakingly prepared measured drawings, large-format photography, and written historical documentation.

The program served two important purposes. It provided meaningful employment for trained architects while creating a permanent archive of America's architectural heritage. Every measured drawing was prepared to professional drafting standards, ensuring that future architects, historians, preservationists, and researchers could rely upon the accuracy of the record.

More than nine decades later, the Historic American Buildings Survey remains one of the nation's most important preservation programs. Thousands of buildings have been documented, creating an extraordinary collection preserved by the Library of Congress and available to researchers throughout the world.

**PART III**

**THE FIELD NOTES**

ME-42 BOOK #1

HISTORIC AMERICAN BUILDINGS SURVEY  
FIELD NOTE BOOK

12

POWNAE BOROUGH - COURT - HOUSE

Building Old Court House

Street and City Cedar Grove, Newry

County and State Lincoln County Maine

( 1760-1761 )

Project No. ME-42

U. S. GOVERNMENT PRINTING OFFICE 46690

## **Recording the Court House**

In July 1936, a small team working for the Historic American Buildings Survey came to Pownalborough Court House to record the building in detail.

By then, 175 years had passed since Samuel Goodwin and his family had occupied the Court House during its earliest years. It was no longer a courthouse, but it had never entirely ceased to be a family place. Goodwin's descendants in the Canby family still used the old building as a vacation home.

For HABS to document the Court House properly, the surveyors needed more than permission to photograph its exterior. They needed access to the building itself. Rooms had to be measured. Doors and windows had to be examined. Stairways, fireplaces, framing, moldings, hardware, and construction details all had to be recorded. The Canbys made their home available for that work, allowing the survey team to examine the building with an intimacy few visitors would ever experience.

Their cooperation was an important part of the preservation process. Generations of Samuel Goodwin's descendants had kept the building standing. Now they were allowing another kind of preservation to take place: the creation of a permanent architectural record.

## **Measuring the Building**

The finished HABS drawings can make the process appear almost effortless. Their lines are precise, their lettering orderly, and their dimensions carefully placed. But those drawings began with people moving through the Court House with pencils, measuring tools, and field notebooks.

The surveyors had to capture enough information at Pownalborough to reconstruct the building on paper later. The notebooks show how methodically they approached that task. One begins with an index laying out much of the work ahead: a plot plan, plans of the individual floors and roof, sections, elevations, and other architectural details. The pages that follow are filled with rough plans, measurements, annotations, and sketches.

Completeness mattered. The formal drawings would be prepared later, away from the Court House. A missing dimension might not reveal itself until a draftsman attempted to reconcile several measurements or draw a particular detail. By then, checking it would mean returning from Portland to Pownalborough and going back into the building.

So the surveyors recorded much more than the dimensions of rooms. They measured wall thicknesses and openings. They examined stairs and framing. They drew profiles of moldings and trim. Doors, windows, fireplaces, entrances, hardware, and structural connections received attention because any of them might be needed when the finished drawings were prepared. The surviving pages show the work becoming increasingly detailed, moving from plans of entire floors to individual architectural elements.

What looks like a crowded pencil sketch was therefore something much more important. It was the surveyor's memory of the building.

## **The Field Notebooks**

The surviving field notes for the Pownalborough Court House are preserved by the Library of Congress as part of the HABS documentation for the building.

Unlike the finished measured drawings, these were working documents. They were made to capture information, not to present it.

That difference is immediately visible.

Lines cross one another. Dimensions crowd the edges of drawings. Notes fill available spaces. Details are enlarged wherever the surveyor needed room to understand them. Some pages contain broad plans of rooms or floors; others concentrate on a doorway, window, section, piece of hardware, or construction detail. The handwriting and pencil lines preserve something largely absent from the finished sheets: the process of figuring the building out.

The notebooks also reveal the scale of the investigation. Recording a historic building did not mean taking a few overall dimensions and photographs. The surveyors worked from the site and floor plans down to details that might easily escape an ordinary visitor's notice. Later notebook pages include studies of entrances, windows, hardware, interior fittings, and structural elements.

For a building already 175 years old, those observations had another value. The surveyors were not simply recording how a building might have been constructed in 1761. They were recording what actually survived in 1936. Original fabric, later alterations, unusual construction, wear, repairs, and evidence of change could all become part of the record.

The field notes therefore preserve something the finished drawings cannot fully convey. They show HABS not as a collection of documents, but as an act of investigation.

## **From Field Notes to Finished Drawings**

When the fieldwork was complete, the surveyors could leave Pownalborough, but their work on the Court House was far from finished.

The measurements, sketches, annotations, and details carried back from the building provided the information from which the formal architectural drawings could be prepared. Rough pencil lines became carefully drafted plans.

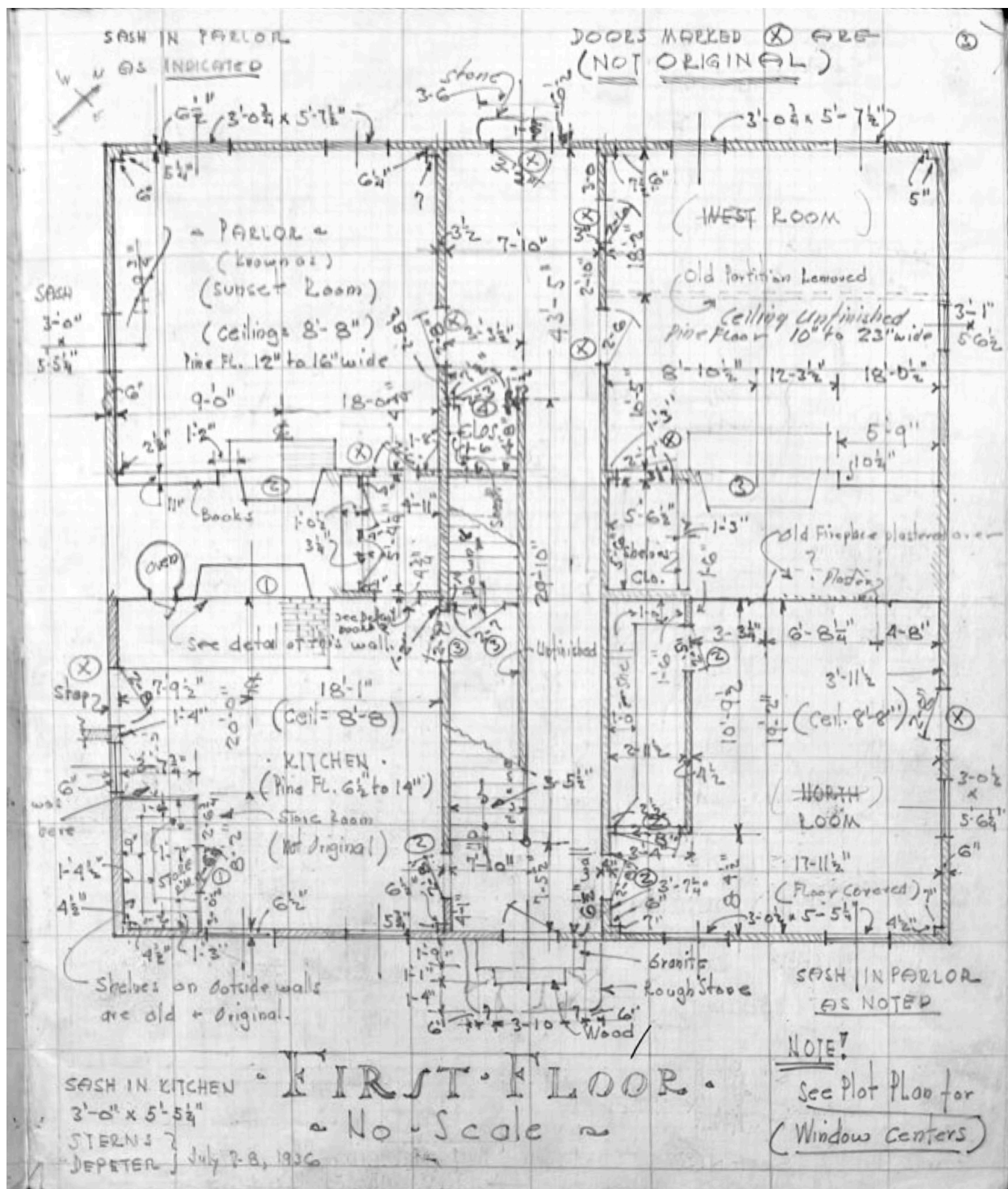
Measurements scattered around notebook pages became ordered dimensions. Individual observations were reconciled into elevations, sections, and details that another architect or historian could understand decades later.

The transformation is striking.

In the field notebooks, we can see the surveyors thinking: measuring, checking, sketching, annotating, and trying to understand how the building was put together. In the finished drawings, that accumulated information becomes a coherent architectural record.

By the time the surveyors left Pownalborough, the Court House existed in two forms. One was the eighteenth-century building still standing above the Kennebec. The other was contained in pages of pencil measurements, sketches, sections, profiles, and notes.

From those pages would come the nineteen measured drawings of the Pownalborough Court House.



## Field Note 3 – First-Floor Plan

The first-floor plan shows what happened when the HABS surveyors moved from the landscape into the Court House itself. Dated July 8, 1936, the day after the plot plan, the page records the building room by room: the parlor, kitchen, west room, north room, central passage, stairs, closets, fireplaces, doors, and windows.

But the surveyors were recording more than dimensions. Notes identify ceiling heights and floorboards, distinguish original features from later changes, and call attention to evidence that might help explain the building's history. In the west room, for example, they noted an “old partition removed,” while elsewhere they identified features as “not original.” Even the window sash received separate attention, with notes directing the draftsman back to the plot plan for window centers.

The page also reveals why field notes were indispensable. Measurements accumulate around walls and openings, details are sketched wherever space permits, and numbered references connect observations that would later have to be reconciled. The drawing is crowded because the surveyors were trying to capture enough information to reconstruct the building after they had left Pownalborough.

Here, perhaps more clearly than anywhere else, we can see the transition between building and drawing. The Court House was being taken apart intellectually, room by room and measurement by measurement, so that it could be assembled again on the drafting table.

These rough pages were never intended to be the final record. They were the evidence from which that record would be made. With the fieldwork complete, the surveyors could return to Portland carrying the Pownalborough Court House with them, on paper.

What follows are the finished HABS drawings created from that work.

## **Author's Note**

Of note, in the North Room (Tavern), the field notes indicate that the fireplace was plastered over. During subsequent restoration, this plaster was removed, revealing a second built-in bake oven. Its original purpose is uncertain. It may have allowed food to be prepared or served independently on the tavern side of the house, or it may reflect a period when the families occupying the Court House kept some kitchen activities separate.

**PART IV**

**THE MEASURED DRAWINGS**



## Sheet 2 – First Floor Plan

The first floor plan introduces readers to the courthouse as its surveyors experienced it in 1936. More than simply showing the arrangement of rooms, this measured drawing captures nearly two centuries of architectural change, documenting both original eighteenth-century construction and later modifications made as the building adapted to new uses.

The plan reveals a remarkably compact and efficient layout centered on a main hall and staircase. Four principal rooms occupy the corners of the building: the Parlor, Kitchen, North Room, and East Room. Thick masonry chimneys stand at the center, allowing fireplaces to heat each of the major rooms while minimizing the amount of masonry required.

One of the strengths of this drawing is the surveyors' close attention to historical evidence. Rather than recording only what existed in 1936, they also identified features that had changed over time. Notes such as "Original Partition Removed" and "Entrance Probably Not Original" demonstrate that the survey team meticulously distinguished between eighteenth-century construction and later alterations whenever physical evidence allowed.

The plan also records spaces that reflect the building's evolution from a colonial courthouse to a nineteenth-century family residence. The wood shed and present kitchen addition appear outside the original footprint, while closets and other interior modifications illustrate how changing needs shaped the building over nearly two centuries of continuous use.

Because every wall, doorway, window, fireplace, and staircase was measured directly from the building, this drawing serves as both an architectural plan and a

historical record. It preserves not only the courthouse's original design but also the evidence of generations who adapted the building to meet their own needs.

## Looking Closer

- **Find the changes.** Look for “Original Partition Removed” and “Entrance Probably Not Original.” What evidence might have led the HABS team to distinguish these features from the original construction?
- **Trace the fireplaces.** Follow the two large masonry masses near the center of the plan and notice how several rooms share them.
- **Find the original footprint.** Compare the main rectangular building with the wood shed and “present kitchen.” The plan makes the later additions surprisingly easy to recognize.
- **Follow a visitor through the building.** Enter through the front door and trace the hall and staircase. The plan reveals circulation in a way an exterior photograph cannot.

**Next:** *With the first floor documented, the survey now continues upstairs, revealing how the building's upper level complemented the public and domestic spaces below.*

## Seeing the Building as a Whole

Having explored the courthouse floor by floor and examined each of its exterior elevations, the Historic American Buildings Survey now combines these separate views into a single drawing. The transverse section slices vertically through the building, revealing how its foundation, floors, staircases, rooms, chimneys, and roof framing work as one integrated structure.

Unlike a floor plan, which looks down from above, or an elevation, which views a building from the outside, a section cuts through the structure itself. By removing one side of the building, the surveyors exposed relationships that could not be seen in any other drawing, allowing readers to understand how the courthouse was constructed from the cellar to the roof.

This drawing serves as the culmination of everything documented so far. The foundation shown in the basement plan, the room arrangements revealed by the floor plans, the roof framing examined in the previous sheet, and the exterior appearance recorded in the elevations all come together here in a single, comprehensive view.

More than any other drawing in this section, the transverse section allows readers to see the courthouse as its builders understood it: not as a collection of individual rooms or façades, but as one precisely engineered structure whose strength depended upon every timber, masonry wall, floor, and chimney working together.



## Sheet 10 – Transverse Section

The transverse section provides one of the most informative drawings in the entire Historic American Buildings Survey. By slicing through the courthouse from foundation to roof, the surveyors reveal the relationships between spaces that no floor plan or exterior elevation can fully explain.

For the first time, readers can follow the central staircase as it rises through every occupied floor, connecting the basement, first, second, and third stories before reaching the attic beneath the roof. The drawing clearly illustrates how each floor is supported by heavy timber framing while the central chimney extends uninterrupted from the cellar to above the roofline.

The section also confirms observations made throughout the earlier drawings. The large courtroom occupies a substantial portion of the second floor, while the bedrooms and hallways align vertically with the spaces below. Notes identifying "Door Not Original" and "Wall and Door Not Original" continue the surveyors' careful distinction between original construction and later alterations, reinforcing that this survey documents both the building's architecture and its history.

Perhaps most impressive is the clarity with which the survey communicates the courthouse's structural system. The stone foundation, heavy framing, stair construction, floor heights, and roof supports are shown working as a single integrated design. What previously required several separate drawings can now be understood at a glance.

For architects, historians, and preservationists, sectional drawings are among the most valuable documents in a measured survey. They reveal not only how a building appears, but how it stands.

## Looking Closer

- **Start underground.** Follow the stone foundation and cellar walls across the drawing, then trace the structure upward through each floor to the attic. A section makes it possible to see how the entire building is supported from the ground up.
- **Follow the stairs.** Begin at the cellar and trace the stairways from one level to the next. Notice that they do not form one continuous straight flight; their position and direction change as they move through the building.
- **Find the Old Court Room.** Its ten-foot ceiling makes the second floor noticeably taller than the floors above and below it. The importance of the courtroom is expressed not only by its size in plan, but by its vertical scale.
- **Look into the attic.** The roof framing that appears abstract in the Roof Framing Plan can now be seen in profile. Rafters, attic floor, chimney, and the occupied floors below can all be understood as parts of the same structural system.

**Next:** *Having examined the courthouse as a complete architectural system, the survey now shifts its attention from the building as a whole to the craftsmanship of its individual features. The remaining sheets explore entrances, fireplaces, doors, hardware, and other architectural details that define the character of one of Maine's most remarkable colonial buildings.*



## Sheet 12 – South-East Entrance

After documenting the courthouse as a complete architectural work, the survey now turns its attention to one of its most important individual features: the principal entrance. More than a means of entering the building, this doorway served as the public face of the courthouse, welcoming judges, lawyers, jurors, witnesses, and citizens for nearly two centuries.

The measured drawing records every component of the entrance, including the door, transom, pilasters, entablature, moldings, and surrounding trim. By enlarging these elements, the surveyors captured details that could never be shown clearly on the exterior elevations.

One note is especially revealing: “All original hardware on this doorway except knocker has been removed.” Rather than ignoring missing elements, this sheet honestly records their absence. This exacting documentation reflects the surveyors’ commitment to accuracy and reminds us that preservation includes recording both what survives and what has been lost.

The enlarged molding profiles are equally valuable. These carefully measured sections preserve the exact shape of the entrance's architectural trim, allowing future craftsmen and preservationists to reproduce the original profiles if repairs or restoration become necessary.

### Looking Closer

- **This is the courthouse's principal entrance.** It formed the public face of the building throughout its years as Lincoln County's courthouse.

- **The doorway is recorded piece by piece.** Rather than drawing only the complete entrance, the survey documents each molding and architectural profile individually.
- **Missing features are documented honestly.** The note regarding the missing door knocker illustrates the surveyors' commitment to recording the building exactly as they found it.

***Next:** Completing the examination of the courthouse's principal entrance, the survey continues with a series of detailed studies that reveal the craftsmanship found throughout the building. Each drawing focuses on a specific architectural feature, preserving the proportions, joinery, and construction techniques that define the courthouse's enduring character.*

**PART V**

**THE PHOTOGRAPHIC RECORD**

# The HABS Photographs

The measured drawings of the Pownalborough Court House record dimensions, construction, and architectural relationships with remarkable precision. The photographs add something different. They show the building as it actually appeared when the Historic American Buildings Survey documented it in 1936: weathered, altered, furnished, and still in use.

The HABS photographic record consists of ten images. The first is an earlier photograph reproduced from what HABS identified only as an “old half-tone illustration.” Its original photographer, date, and source are not given.

Architectural evidence, however, places the building within an earlier period of its history, when its exterior was covered with shingles.

The remaining nine photographs were made by HABS photographer Allen L. Hubbard on July 14, 1936, as part of survey ME-42. Together they form a deliberate progression. Hubbard first recorded the south-east and north-west elevations, then moved closer to document the principal entrances and the distinctive front-door knocker. The final four photographs take the viewer inside, from a first-floor fireplace through the second-floor hallway and north-east room, ending in the comparatively unfinished north-west room on the third floor.

These photographs are particularly valuable because the Court House Hubbard encountered was not a restored representation of the building as it appeared in 1761. Nearly 175 years of use separated its construction from the HABS survey. During that time the building had served as a courthouse, tavern, place of worship, post office, and family residence. Rooms had been divided and remodeled, windows and doors replaced, exterior finishes changed, stairs

repaired, domestic additions constructed, and successive generations had adapted the building to their needs.

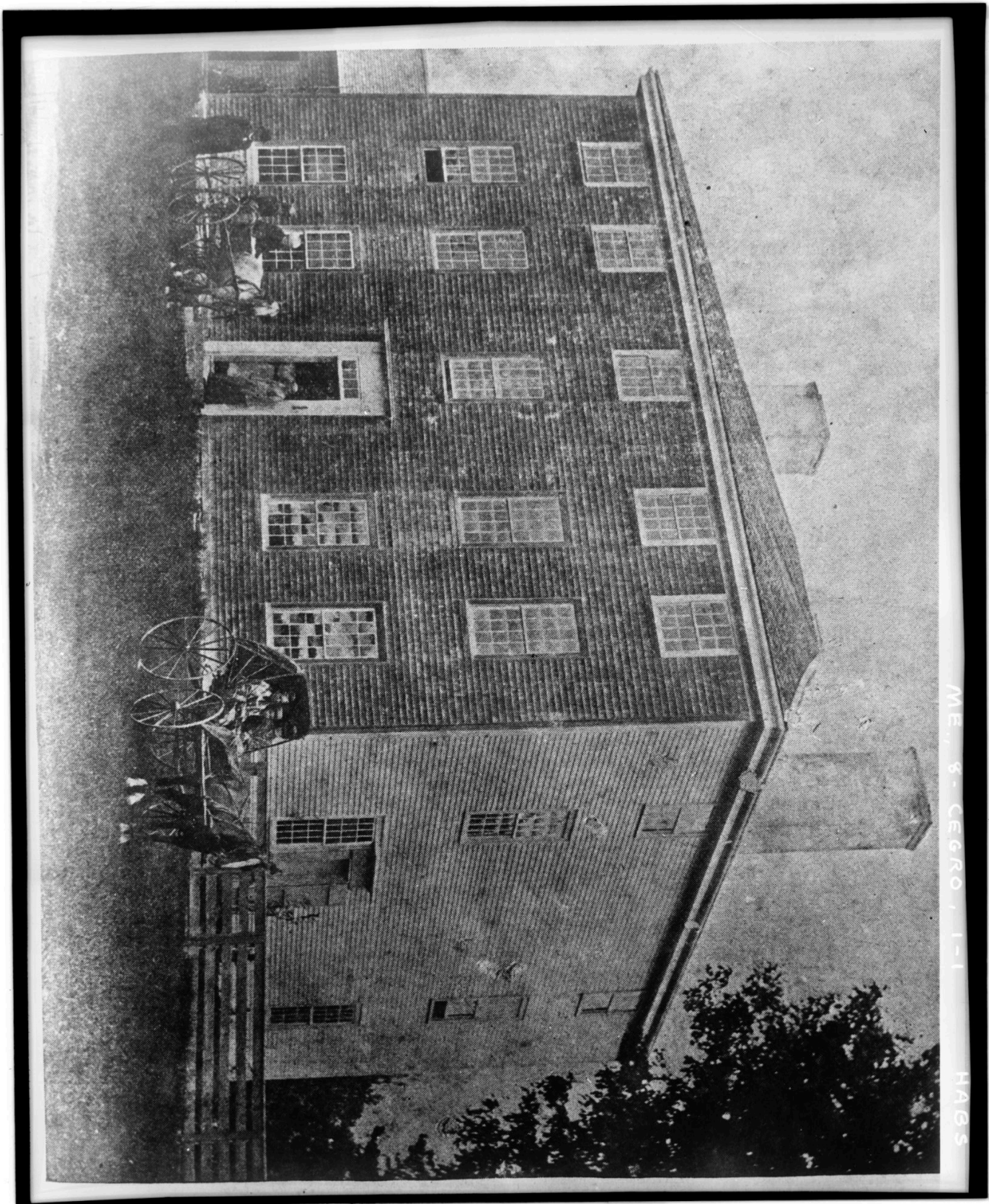
Consequently, the alterations visible in the photographs are themselves part of the historical record. Later research, particularly Martha Vaughan's detailed study of the construction and alteration of the Court House, makes it possible to associate some of the features photographed in 1936 with documented changes made during the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. In other cases, the date or origin of a surviving feature remains uncertain, and the photographs provide evidence without necessarily providing an answer.

The images also preserve things that measured drawings cannot easily convey: worn surfaces, irregular construction, wallpaper and furnishings, plants around the foundation, objects left beside the house, and the different character of finished and unfinished rooms. Even an automobile parked at the edge of an exterior view becomes part of the moment Hubbard recorded.

Viewed together with the nineteen measured drawings, the photographs provide a second way of reading the building. The drawings explain how the Court House was constructed and organized. The photographs show what almost two centuries of occupation had done to it. Together they preserve not a building frozen at the moment of its construction, but the Pownalborough Court House as history had left it in 1936.

## **Author's Note**

Light and tone levels on four of the interior photographs were adjusted to make details in the original images more visible. No architectural features were added, removed, or altered.



ME. 8 - CEGRO, 1-1 HAGS

## **Photograph 1 – From an Old Half-Tone Illustration**

The first image in the HABS photographic record predates the 1936 photographic survey. The Library of Congress identifies it only as “FROM OLD HALF-TONE ILLUSTRATION,” without naming the photographer, the original publication, or the date of the underlying photograph. It was nevertheless preserved as the first of the ten photographs associated with the Pownalborough Court House survey.

The photograph is especially valuable because it records an appearance of the Court House that had disappeared long before the HABS team arrived. Both visible sides of the building are covered with wooden shingles. Martha Vaughan’s detailed study of alterations to the Court House explains that the building was originally finished with clapboards on the front and rear and shingles on the two ends. In 1832, these coverings were removed and all four sides were shingled. In 1871, Captain Samuel Randolph Goodwin had the shingles removed and replaced with clapboards.

The photograph therefore appears to show the Court House during its nineteenth-century all-shingled period. Although the architectural evidence helps narrow the period represented, the original photograph remains undated, and a more precise date cannot presently be assigned.

Other details make the image particularly useful for comparison with the later HABS record. The numerous small panes of glass recall the HABS description of the building’s early windows, while the entrances, window openings, chimneys, and fencing can be compared directly with the measured drawings and the photographs made in 1936. The people, horses, and carriages gathered before the building also distinguish this image from the deliberately architectural views

that follow. Here the Court House is not simply a structure being documented, but an occupied building within its nineteenth-century landscape.

Another key change visible in this photograph is the earlier 12-over-12-pane window configuration. By 1936, some of these had been replaced by later windows, as seen in the second and third photographs. These replacements may date to the Victorian era. The windows were subsequently restored to their earlier configuration.

By 1936, the exterior had changed substantially. The shingles visible here were gone, and HABS recorded a clapboarded building. This first photograph therefore serves as an appropriate introduction to the photographic record: before showing the Court House as the surveyors found it, HABS preserved a glimpse of an earlier Court House that had already disappeared.

## Looking Closer

- **Look at the siding.** Both visible elevations are covered with wooden shingles. That seemingly ordinary detail is what helps date the scene: the Court House was entirely shingled beginning in 1832, and the shingles were replaced with clapboards in 1871.
- **Count the window panes.** The photograph preserves the earlier 12-over-12 sash that was later replaced in some openings. Compare these windows with Photographs 2 and 3, made in 1936, and the changes become immediately visible.
- **Look at the people, horses, and carriages.** Unlike Hubbard's carefully composed architectural photographs, this image captures activity around the Court House. Clothing, vehicles, fencing, and other incidental details may



## **Photograph 7 – Mantel, South-East Room, First Floor**

With Photograph 7, the HABS record moves inside the Court House, beginning with the fireplace and mantel in the south-east room on the first floor. It is also the first photograph in the series to show how an interior was furnished and occupied at the time of the survey.

The fireplace is enormous by later domestic standards. Its broad opening, deep brick firebox, iron crane, and andirons reflect the importance of the hearth in a building constructed before modern heating and cooking. HABS described the original kitchen as being on the left side of the central hall, while Martha Vaughan's research places Major Samuel Goodwin's kitchen and parlor on the south side of the first floor during the early occupation of the Court House.

The photograph is particularly useful because it shows the relationship between surviving architecture and generations of domestic use. The fireplace itself is massive and utilitarian, while the restrained wooden mantel and surrounding paneling incorporate it into a finished room. As elsewhere in the building, not every visible element can be assumed to date from 1761; the Court House underwent repeated repairs and alterations.

The furnishings add another layer of evidence. Plates, candlesticks, a mug, framed pictures, chairs, and other objects surround the fireplace, while firewood and kindling lie on the hearth. HABS does not identify these objects or establish their age, so they should not be interpreted automatically as original furnishings. Instead, they record the appearance and use of the room in 1936.

The image also helps explain why the fireplaces and chimneys occupy so much space in the measured plans. What appears there simply as a substantial mass of masonry becomes here a hearth large enough to dominate an entire wall. In a

building that served as courthouse, tavern, place of worship, and home during its early history, fireplaces such as this were essential working features.

## Looking Closer

- **Use the furniture for scale.** The chair beside the hearth helps reveal just how large the fireplace opening is. What appears as a rectangular feature in the measured drawings becomes an architectural space in its own right when seen beside ordinary household furniture.
- **Look inside the firebox.** The photograph preserves not simply the masonry but some of the equipment associated with using the hearth. The iron crane could swing cooking vessels toward or away from the fire, while andirons supported burning wood. Together they help us understand the fireplace as working equipment rather than decoration.
- **Look around the fireplace.** Plates, candlesticks, framed pictures, chairs, firewood, and other household objects remain in view. Hubbard's photograph consequently records two histories at once: the architecture of the eighteenth-century Court House and the domestic environment encountered by HABS in 1936.

**PART VI**

**THE WRITTEN RECORD**

"POWNALEBOROUGH COURT HOUSE"

Cedar Grove, Dresden, Lincoln County, Maine

Owner

Oliver Canby

Date of Erection

1761

Builder

Major Samuel Goodwin, Agent for the Plymouth Company. Work of building under the general direction of Gershom Flagg, a kind of master builder who was termed a "housewright and glazier".

Present Condition

The interior of the building has had slight alterations. Space formerly occupied by the court room (45' x 20') has been partitioned off to form three rooms. The court room occupied the rear half of the second floor of the structure and it is believed that the bench was toward the center of the building. Sash has nearly all been replaced. Exterior walls are clapboarded. Blinds have been added to the windows in recent years. Gutters have been installed.

Number of Stories

Three

Materials of Construction

Foundation stone. The building has the appearance of being built directly on the ground. The first floor level is about a foot above the ground level. Floors are pine. The building originally had twenty-four light windows. Exterior walls were originally shingled. Some of the interior walls have been plastered. The walls of the original kitchen at the left of the central hall are plain board finish, painted white. The walls and ceilings of the third floor rooms show heavy timber construction. Walls are of pine set perpendicularly. Brick in fireplaces and chimneys laid in clay. Stairs throughout the three floors of the court house are of thick plank. In the hall of the court house, pine boards have been set vertically to form staving. First floor walls in the hall have been painted but through second and third floors, the walls are unfinished.

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Other Existing Records

Old Colonial Houses in Mains by Emma Huntington Nason.  
History of Dresden, Maine by Charles Edwin Allen.

Additional Data

Ref. History of Dresden, Maine. On the 12th of December 1760, Samuel Goodwin certified on the plan of the three acre lots that there was: "A House to Hold the County Courts in of three Story High and 45 feet long and 44 feet wide now abuilding by the Kennebec in Pownalborough on Kennebeck River".

The court house is built on the former site of the parade ground of Fort Shirley. The eastern most blockhouss of Fort Shirley with the land on which it stood was appropriated for a Gaol.

The court house building was used by the Plymouth Company as a court of law and as a place of worship. Major Samuel Goodwin and his family occupied the living quarters on the east side of the building and also conducted a tavern there.

Evidently people from far and wide were in the habit of attending court as in 1767 a complaint was made, stating that strangers attending court "have to lodge on the floor, or in barns, or sit up all night by the fire".

The History of Dresden, Maine, states that there were whipping posts and stocks near the court house, and several hangings took place on a hill near the building where they could be plainly viewed from the Kennebec River.

John Adams, later president of the U. S. and Robert Treat Paine, ons of the signers of the Declaration of Independence pleaded law cases at the Pownalborough Court House.

The Court House was Dresden's first post office and was used as such for many years.

Chas. E. Jannell

Approved:

James T. Tully

Date:

Dec 18 1936

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## Written Historical and Descriptive Data

The measured drawings and photographs created by the Historic American Buildings Survey preserve the Pownalborough Court House as it appeared in 1936. The written record adds something different. In two typewritten pages, the surveyors attempted to summarize the building's construction, condition, historical associations, and the changes that had occurred during its first 175 years.

The record identifies Oliver Canby as the owner, gives 1761 as the date of erection, and names Major Samuel Goodwin, agent for the Plymouth Company, as the builder. It further states that construction was carried out under the general direction of Gersham Flagg, described as a master builder and a "housewright and glazier."

### The Building in 1936

The surveyors characterized the interior as having undergone only "slight alterations," but immediately documented one substantial change. The original courtroom, approximately 45 by 20 feet, had been partitioned into three rooms. They placed the courtroom in the rear half of the second floor and believed that its bench had stood toward the center of the building.

Other changes were more incremental. Nearly all of the window sash had been replaced. The exterior was clapboarded, blinds had been added in recent years, and gutters had been installed. These observations are particularly valuable because they distinguish features visible in the 1936 photographs from elements the surveyors understood to be original.

## Materials and Construction

The written record also provides details that are not always apparent in the measured drawings.

The foundation was stone, although the building appeared to sit almost directly on the ground, with the first-floor level only about a foot above grade. Floors were pine. According to the survey, the building originally had twenty-four-light windows, and its exterior walls were originally shingled rather than clapboarded.

Inside, the surveyors noted that some walls had been plastered while the original kitchen retained plain board walls painted white. On the third floor, heavy timber construction remained exposed, with pine boards set vertically. Fireplace and chimney brickwork was laid in clay, the stairs throughout the building were constructed of thick plank, and vertical pine boards formed the wall treatment in the central hall. The first-floor hall had been painted, while the second and third floors remained unfinished.

Read alongside the photographs and measured drawings, these short descriptions become especially useful. They tell us not simply what the surveyors saw, but what they believed represented original construction and what they understood to be later alteration.

## A Building with Many Uses

The second page moves away from architectural description and into history.

For its historical information, the survey specifically identifies two existing sources: Emma Huntington Nason's *Old Colonial Houses in Maine* and Charles Edwin Allen's *History of Dresden, Maine*.